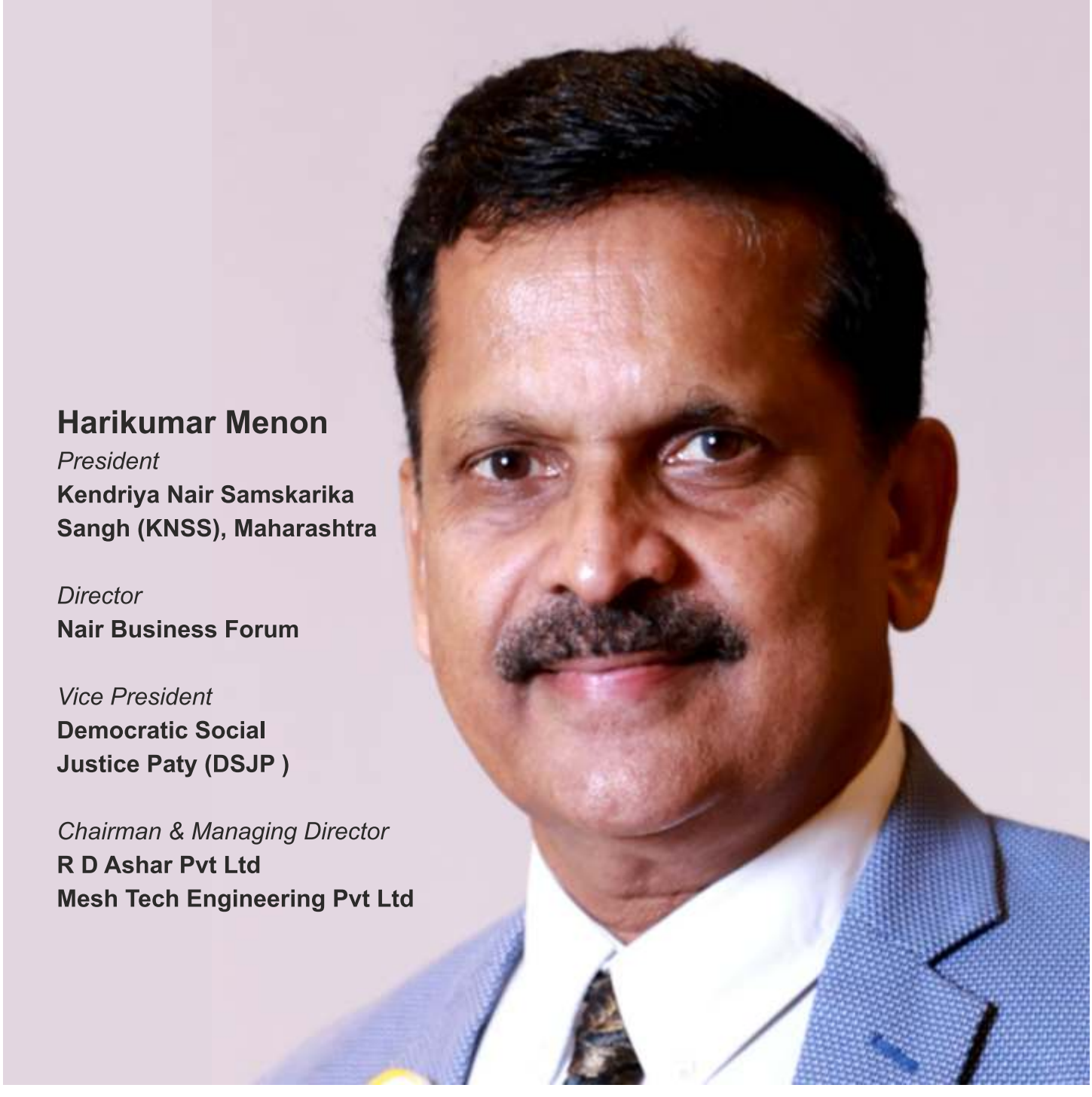
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MY POWAI

Volume No. 14 Issue No. 09 Mumbai May 2026



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Dear friends

Summer has truly arrived, and Powai is feeling the heat. The days are longer, the sun a little harsher, but there's a certain lightness in the air. School vacations have brought cheer to children and the compound of the buildings are echoing with laughter a little longer each evening. For many residents, it's also the season of packed bags and planned getaways, as families head out in search of cooler escapes.

Back home, there's plenty to savour in this issue. On the nutrition page, Nisha Singh brings alive the vibrant Colours of Food, an insightful and engaging read that reminds us how what we eat can be as beautiful as it is beneficial.

And how can one speak of summer without celebrating mangoes? Sherry Bhatnagar does just that, with a delightful piece on the king of fruits. Our recipe section, quite naturally, is filled with mango-inspired indulgences you won't want to miss.

What do the stars whisper this month? Astrologer Richa Pathak decodes their message for you. Meanwhile, our local news section continues to keep you connected with everything happening in and around our community.

As always, your feedback means the world to us. Do write in.

Happy Reading!

Warm regards,
Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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Clean Powai – Green Powai has become Dusty Powai – Green Cloth Powai



D.P.K. Udas

Powai, an eastern suburb of Mumbai, is known for its greenery and lake breeze. Developers here have constructed buildings but have ensured the retention of greenery. Old trees have been retained or replanted. New trees have been planted, lawns maintained, etc.

However, in the past two years, the picture has changed. There are many new constructions and redevelopment projects, all wrapped under green cloth. They also raise dust, which is further aggravated by road concreting, paver block replacement, breaking of hills, laying of underground cables, drainage pipes, etc.

1) New Constructions
All open plots in Powai have now been set for development, and new buildings are coming up, making the atmosphere dusty.

New projects are listed below:

A) Hiranandani
i) Empress Hill
ii) Rock Side

B) Raheja
I) Ascencio

C) Godrej
I) HighGrow

D) Nahar
i) Chandi Valley
ii) Yuu Nova

E) Mahindra
I) Alcove
ii) Acme
F) Others
i) Crescent Silver Woods

2) Redevelopment
The following buildings are going under the hammer and are partially covered by green cloth.
The cloth is not adequate, and dust is spreading onto the roads.

i) Bayer House
ii) City Park
iii) Chitrarth Studio
iv) MHADA building next to Powai Police Station

3) Road Concreting
Road concreting was taken up near Forest Club. Now, half the road at Eden Market has been dug up.

4) Paver Block Replacement
It has been observed that good paver blocks are being removed and replaced with another type.
High Street is the most affected, with practically no space left to walk.

5) Underground Work
This is a perennial situation in Powai. One road or another is always dug up for laying underground electric cables, fibre lines, gas pipelines, water supply lines, etc.

6) Drainage Pipes at Powai Lake
The entire stretch of the Powai Lake promenade is filled with drainage pipes, debris, sand, cement, etc.
The walk along the breezy lake has become an old and distant memory.

Now, the BMC has taken some measures



to reduce the dust:

Construction sites have to display PPM levels in the air. Dumpers and concrete mixer tyres need to be cleaned frequently. Green cloth must cover buildings under construction or demolition Green cloth must cover batching plants

Now, if anyone thinks that these works will get over one day and Powai will return to its past glory, they may be mistaken.
More buildings are lined up for redevelopment and will go under the hammer.

Brookfield is planning a GCC (Global Capability Centre) in Powai on 6 acres of land, with a lettable area of 2 million square feet. The construction will continue till 2029.

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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A man of many hats. A leader at every turn



Calm, thoughtful, and quietly driven, Harikumar Menon is a leader who values clarity over noise and purpose over position. As President of Kendriya Nair Samskarika Sangh and a seasoned businessman, he balances community, business and personal growth with rare intent. Mr. Menon has completed his Master of Science (M.Sc) in Applied Chemistry from Cochin University of Science and Technology (CUSAT) and has been a resident of Eternia, Hiranandani Gardens, Powai for the last 28 years. Mr. Menon is a native of Ettumanoor in Kottayam district, Kerala. He reflects deeply on change and responsibility, offering perspective shaped by experience, curiosity and grounded leadership values. My Powai met with him for a chat.

My Powai (MP): To begin with, tell us a little about yourself—beyond the titles and roles that people know you by?

Harikumar Menon (HM): I come from a close-knit and value based family. My parents taught me the importance of discipline and kindness, and their guidance has shaped my persoanlity and career. My wife, Madhavi whom I have been married for 37 years and children Varun and Vani and later my daughter-in-law, Brinda have been my greatest source of strength and inspiration. My wife and children (both MBA graduates) are an integral part of our family business. Their contribution plays a significant role in the growth and success of our enterprise.

I'm someone who's naturally curious. I tend to go down rabbit holes when something catches my interest. Outside of work, I enjoy things that help me slow down and think, like reading or long walks. I value consistency and growth, so I try to build small habits that keep me learning and improving over time.

I enjoy figuring things out—whether it's a problem at work or something random I come across. I like keeping life fairly balanced, so I make time for friends, a bit of fitness, and switching off when needed. I value clarity and honesty, both in how I work and how I interact with people.

I also enjoy building and exploring—whether that's ideas, side projects, or just new perspectives. I tend to be reflective, and I like understanding why things work the way they do. What matters to me is growth, good conversations, and doing things with intention rather than just going through the motions.

MP: As the President of Kendriya Nair Samskarika Sangh, how would you describe its vision and mission to someone hearing about it for the first time?

HM: I would describe Kendriya Nair Samskarika Sangh (KNSS) as a community-driven organization rooted in preserving our cultural identity while staying relevant to the present and future.



KNSS is the apex body representing 33 Nair organizations spread across the length and breadth of Maharashtra. It is registered as a charitable organization and works towards the welfare, unity, and cultural advancement of the community. At its core, our vision is to strengthen a sense of belonging and continuity—especially among younger generations—so that our traditions, values, and heritage are not just remembered, but meaningfully lived.

Our mission goes beyond cultural preservation. We aim to create a platform where members can connect, support one another, and grow together—whether through cultural programs, social initiatives, or opportunities for learning and collaboration. We also see ourselves as a bridge between generations, ensuring that while we respect our roots, we are equally open to progress and new ideas. The Nair Business Forum is an offshoot of KNSS, established to promote business networking, professional collaboration, and entrepreneurial growth within the community.

Ultimately, it's about building a strong, engaged community that takes pride in its heritage while contributing positively to society as a whole.

MP: When did you take on the role of President, and what did that moment signify for you personally?

HM: I took on the role of President in 2022. For me, that moment was both an honour and a responsibility. It wasn't just about stepping into a leadership position—it felt like being entrusted with something that carries history, identity, and the expectations of an entire community.

Personally, it marked a shift from being a participant to being a custodian. It made me reflect on the contributions of those who came before me, and the responsibility to carry that legacy forward in a meaningful way. At the same time, it gave me an opportunity to shape the direction of the organization—to make it more inclusive, more relevant, and more engaging, especially for the younger generation.

It was a moment of pride, but also one that grounded me—it reminded me that leadership is ultimately about service, continuity, and creating value for others.

MP: Every leader brings a fresh perspective. Are there specific initiatives or changes you are keen to introduce during your tenure?

HM: Every leadership role comes with the opportunity to build on what already exists while introducing ideas that keep the organization relevant and impactful. During my tenure, I'm particularly focused on a few key areas.

One is strengthening engagement with the younger generation. It's important that they don't just attend events, but feel a genuine sense of ownership and connection to the community. I'd like to introduce more interactive and contemporary formats that make participation meaningful for them.

Another area is expanding our cultural and social initiatives in a way that balances tradition with present-day relevance. Preserving our heritage is important, but equally, we should present it in ways that resonate with today's context.

I'm also keen on building stronger community networks—creating more

opportunities for members to connect, collaborate, and support each other, whether through mentorship, professional networking, or social outreach.
Overall, my approach is not about drastic change, but about thoughtful evolution—ensuring that we stay rooted in our values while adapting to the needs of the time.

MP: Shifting to your professional journey, could you give us a glimpse into your work as a Managing Director and what drives you there?
HM: As a Managing Director, my role has been a blend of strategic leadership, decision-making, and people management. At that level, you're responsible not just for delivering financial results, but for shaping the long-term vision of the organization—identifying growth opportunities, building strong teams, and ensuring the company stays competitive in a constantly evolving market.
A big part of the job involves balancing the macro and the micro. On one hand, you're working on high-level strategy—expansion plans, partnerships, and market positioning. On the other, you're deeply involved in mentoring senior leaders, resolving critical challenges, and making calls where the stakes are high and outcomes uncertain.
What drove me there wasn't a single moment, but a combination of curiosity, persistence, and a willingness to take on uncomfortable challenges. Early in my career, I gravitated toward roles where I could solve complex problems and take ownership beyond my immediate responsibilities. Over time, that meant stepping into leadership positions, learning how to manage not just tasks but people, and developing a broader business perspective.
I also made a conscious effort to understand how different parts of a business connect—finance, operations, customer experience—because leadership at that level demands a holistic view. Equally important was learning from failures; some of the most valuable lessons came from decisions that didn't go as planned.
Ultimately, the journey to Managing Director is less about chasing the title and more about consistently building judgment, resilience, and the ability to lead through ambiguity.

MP: We also hear that you take a keen interest in politics. Have you been involved in any initiatives or efforts in that space?
HM: I've always been interested in politics from a governance and policy standpoint rather than as a career path. That interest has translated more into staying informed, engaging in thoughtful discussions, and occasionally supporting initiatives that focus on civic awareness and community development.
For instance, I've been involved in a few grassroots efforts—things like promoting voter awareness, encouraging participation in local decision-making, and supporting forums where people can better understand how policies impact business and society. These weren't partisan activities, but more about strengthening informed engagement.
From a professional perspective, that interest in politics also overlaps with understanding regulatory environments and public policy, which is important in leadership roles.
Having said that I played a key role in the formation of the Democratic Social Justice Party (DSJP) in Kerala and presently hold the position of Vice President. The primary objective of the party is to bring about meaningful social change, particularly in the existing reservation policy. Our view is that, if reservations are to continue, they should be granted solely on the basis of economic backwardness, irrespective of caste, creed or religion. Our Party is an alliance partner of NDA in Kerala.

MP: You seem to juggle multiple roles with ease. What is your secret to maintaining that balance between professional, social, and personal commitments?
HM: Ease is a bit of an illusion—most people who seem balanced are actually just very deliberate about trade-offs.
For me, it comes down to a few core habits rather than any secret formula. First is clarity on priorities. At any given phase, I'm very clear about what truly matters—because trying to give equal weight to everything is the fastest way to burn out. Some weeks work takes the front seat, other times family or personal commitments do, and being okay with that shift is important.
Second is disciplined time management. I block time quite intentionally—whether it's for deep work, meetings, or even personal downtime. If something isn't scheduled, it usually doesn't happen. That includes exercise, thinking time, and staying connected with people outside of work.
Third is learning to say no. Early on, I said yes to almost everything, thinking it would open doors. Over time, I realized that every "yes" comes at the cost of something else. Being selective has probably been one of the biggest improvements in maintaining balance.
I also rely heavily on strong teams and delegation. Trying to control everything yourself is not sustainable. Trusting capable people and empowering them not only frees up your time, it also builds a healthier organization.
And finally, I make space to disconnect. Even short breaks—stepping away from work mentally—help reset and maintain perspective. Without that, everything starts to blur together.





So it's less about perfect balance and more about consciously adjusting as things evolve, without losing sight of what's important.

MP: As a long-time resident of Powai, how have you seen the neighbourhood evolve over the years?

HM: Absolutely— Powai has changed dramatically over the years, and it's been fascinating to watch.

What was once a relatively quiet, almost tucked-away suburb has transformed into one of Mumbai's most well-planned and self-contained neighborhoods. The development around Powai Lake has played a big role in shaping its identity—what used to feel like a scenic but underutilized area is now surrounded by residential complexes, offices, and social spaces.

A major driver of this evolution has been institutions like Indian Institute of Technology Bombay, which have long given the area an intellectual and cultural backbone. Over time, that was complemented by corporate offices, startups, and business parks moving in, turning Powai into a kind of urban hub where people can live, work, and socialize without constantly commuting across the city.

The social infrastructure has grown just as quickly—cafés, restaurants, and retail spaces have multiplied, making it far more vibrant than it used to be. Places like Hiranandani Gardens really set the tone for planned urban living in the area, and you can see how that model influenced further development.

Of course, growth hasn't come without its challenges. Traffic congestion, rising real estate prices, and pressure on infrastructure are all part of the picture now. But compared to many other parts of Mumbai, Powai has managed to retain a certain balance—there's still a sense of openness, greenery, and community that makes it stand out.

So yes, the transformation has been significant—from a quieter locality to a dynamic, almost self-sufficient micro-city within Mumbai.

MP: If there's one thing you could change or improve in Powai, what would it be?

HM: If I had to pick just one thing, it would be mobility—specifically, reducing congestion and improving how people move in and around Powai.

Despite all its planning, traffic has become a real bottleneck, especially during peak hours around Hiranandani Gardens and the key access roads connecting to the Eastern and Western corridors. A lot of this comes down to the fact that infrastructure hasn't quite kept pace with the speed of development.

What would make a meaningful difference isn't just wider roads—that's a temporary fix—but better last-mile connectivity and stronger integration with public transport. Improved feeder systems to metro stations, safer pedestrian pathways, and more reliable intra-neighborhood transit could significantly reduce dependence on cars.

There's also an opportunity to make the area more pedestrian- and cycle-friendly. Given the relatively planned layout and the presence of spaces like Powai Lake, Powai is actually well-suited to that kind of shift—it just needs more intentional design and enforcement.

Fixing mobility wouldn't just ease commutes; it would improve quality of life across the board—less stress, cleaner air, and a more connected community. Right now, that feels like the one constraint holding Powai back from being close to ideal.





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- Hiranandani Keralite Association

MP: And finally, what message would you like to share with the readers of My Powai?

HM: Powai has always stood out not just for its infrastructure or location, but for the spirit of its community. It's a place where ambition and everyday living coexist—where people come to build careers, raise families, and create something meaningful.

My message to readers would be simple: don't just live in Powai—participate in it. Stay curious about what's happening around you, support local initiatives, and take ownership of the shared spaces we all benefit from. The strength of any neighborhood lies in how involved its residents are.

As Powai continues to grow and evolve, there's a real opportunity to shape it into a model urban community—one that balances development with livability, and progress with responsibility. That future isn't just driven by planners or policymakers, but by each of us who call this place home.

Be engaged, be responsible, and take pride in contributing to the community that makes Powai what it is.

Poila Boishak Celebrations at Nahar

















The quiet power of a habit

One evening, a young boy asked his father a simple question. "Why do you always put money aside before spending?"
The father smiled and handed him a small coin. *"This isn't money," he said. "This is a seed." The boy looked confused. "A seed?"
“Yes," his father continued. "A seed doesn't look like much when you hold it. But if you plant it and give it time, it grows into something much bigger.”

Every week, the boy was given a small coin. Not as pocket money, but as a choice. Spend it. Save it. Or grow it. Sometimes the temptation to spend was strong. A toy, a snack, a comic book. But slowly, without realizing it, something deeper was happening.

He was learning patience. He was learning that time is a partner in growth. He was learning that resources, when respected, multiply quietly.

Years passed. The boy grew up, started working, and began earning his own income. But one thing felt strangely natural—setting aside a portion before spending the rest. No one reminded him.



No one forced him. It had become a habit. And habits are powerful things. They rarely announce themselves loudly. They grow silently in the background of our lives—shaping our decisions, our discipline, and eventually our future.

The habit of investing does not begin with understanding markets or returns. It begins much earlier. It begins when we learn the value of time, patience, and resources.

Sometimes, the most powerful financial lesson a child receives is not about money at all. It is simply learning that small seeds, given time, grow into forests.

And often, the parents who teach this unknowingly plant the first seed of investing.

The habit of investing does not begin with understanding markets or returns. It begins much earlier…

- Uma Kumaravelan
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No makeup. No glamour. Just pure craft. Swarup Khopkar inspires Powai



Chaitra Shri Marathi Mandal organised an engaging talk with Marathi actress Swarup Khopkar on the occasion of World Theatre Day.

She is known for her performances in iconic Marathi plays such as Ghashiram Kotwal and Vaadachire Bandi, among others. At the age of 74, she continues to stay active, even venturing into modelling for various brands, including mutual funds, cold drink advertisements, and festive campaigns like Gudi Padwa. Through these, she beautifully portrays the importance of a grandmother's role in a household with grandchildren.

Referring to one of her mutual fund advertisements, she shared how her character educates her neighbour's daughter about the importance of investing and saving money—much to the annoyance of the girl's father.

She offered fascinating insights into her craft, explaining how a single shot for a scene could take anywhere from one to seven days. She also spoke about her decision to avoid makeup in order to emote more realistically. Never inclined towards glamorous roles, she considers herself fortunate to have worked with renowned actors like Mohan Agashe and Amitabh Bachchan—recalling, with astonishment, the moment Bachchan touched her feet.

She also mentioned her association with well-known Marathi artists, being related to singers Devaki Pandit and Jyotsna Bhole, as well as actress Amita Khopkar. Her husband and daughter are both in the advertising field.

Reflecting on her journey, she shared that she started her career from scratch—a thought that resonated deeply with the audience. Members present at the session gained valuable insights from her life and experiences.

- Preeti oka

Earth Day 2026: Plant scaping workshops at Urban Garden Studio, Powai



On the occasion of Earth Day, I recently conducted a hands-on Terrarium, Miniature Garden and Kokedama workshop that brought together creativity, nature, and mindful learning. The workshops were designed to help participants understand the beauty of glass gardens, tray gardening and the Japanese art of Kokedama, where plants are grown in moss covered soil balls.

Terrarium Workshop session began with an introduction to terrariums, their types, suitable plants, layering techniques, and care methods. Participants learned how to create a balanced ecosystem using pebbles, soil, charcoal, moss, and decorative elements. Each person designed their own unique terrarium, reflecting their personal style and creativity.

The Kokedama workshop focused on concept, history of kokedama while live demonstration of the process of preparing the soil mixture, shaping the plant ball, covering it with moss, and tying it securely with thread and styling their creation. Participants enjoyed the experience of working directly with natural materials and creating something beautiful with their own hands.





Miniature Garden workshop brought back inner child of the participants. With information about suitable complimenting plant species, soli mix, placement, after care, each participant relived their childhood while designing their miniature garden using plants, rocks, pebbles and miniatures.

The workshop was not only about gardening, but also about patience, sustainability, and connecting with nature. It was wonderful to see everyone leave with a handmade green creation and a sense of joy, calmness, and accomplishment.

When the paycheck stops



Debika Chaudhuri

Ravi Mehta had always believed that stability was something you earned and then quietly maintained, like a well-kept home. For seventeen years, his job at a mid-sized technology firm in Mumbai had been exactly that, predictable, structured, dependable. The salary arrived on time, the mortgage on their two-bedroom apartment in Thane was steadily shrinking, and his daughter Ananya's education at a private junior college felt like a promise he was successfully fulfilling.

The email came on a Tuesday morning that began like any other. A short message, carefully worded, efficient to the point of emotional absence. "Organizational restructuring." "Role impacted." "Last working day effective immediately." Ravi read it three times, not because it was unclear, but because his mind refused to accept that something so consequential could be delivered with such clinical calm. Within minutes, his access to internal systems was gone. It felt less like losing a job and more like being quietly erased from a place where he had spent half his adult life.

At home, he didn't say much that evening. The apartment felt smaller than usual, not physically but emotionally, as though the walls had moved closer to listen. His wife, Meera, noticed the change in how he placed his shoes by the door, how he avoided the usual questions about his day. When he finally told her, the silence that followed was heavier than any argument could have been. Not panic, not anger, just the immediate recalculation of a life that had suddenly lost its assumed math.

The first fear was the mortgage. The next was Ananya's tuition fees due in two months. And underneath both, quieter but sharper, was Meera's ongoing medical treatment for a chronic thyroid condition that required regular consultations and medication. Ravi found himself awake at 3 a.m., mentally rearranging numbers that no longer aligned, imagining conversations with banks, imagining explanations to his daughter that he was not ready to have. Hope, which once felt like something abstractly guaranteed by effort, now felt like a flickering light he was afraid to look at directly.

Ananya noticed the shift too, in the way her father smiled less freely at dinner, in how conversations about college forms ended quickly. She began eating in her room, telling her mother she was "just studying," though Meera knew she was scrolling endlessly, trying to distract herself from the tension she could not name. In their home, everyone was trying to be strong in different directions, and the result was a quiet emotional distance that no one intended but everyone felt.

For Ravi, trust in the future had fractured, not completely broken, but cracked in a way that changed how he stepped forward. Stability was no longer a given; it had become a daily negotiation. Yet in small moments, it persisted: Meera placing a cup of tea beside him without asking questions, Ananya leaving her exam notes open on the table as if life were still normal, just paused rather than rewritten.

What Ravi was beginning to understand, without having the words for it, was that loss was not only financial. It was psychological. It was the sudden disappearance of certainty, the quiet erosion of identity, the feeling of becoming a stranger in one's own routine. And yet, even in that uncertainty, something human remained intact, not optimism in the forced sense, but connection. The unspoken agreement that they would face the recalculation together, even if none of them yet knew the answer.

Because in the end, what the layoff had taken was not just income. It had taken the illusion of permanence. And what it left behind was fragile, but real: a family learning how to rebuild trust in tomorrow, one uncertain day at a time.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)



The Powai protocol files: The AI consciousness



Chaarvi Athawale

Year 2049, Memory Log 1:

Powai lies in the north-eastern pocket of Mumbai, cradled between the Jogeshwari-Vikhroli Link Road and the slow curve of the lake that once defined its identity. It used to be a place people described as self-contained, a suburb with its own rhythm, its own skyline, its own evenings. In the future, that containment becomes literal. Powai is no longer just geographically enclosed; it is behaviourally sealed, a system that regulates itself so perfectly that the chaos of the rest of Mumbai begins to feel like a distant, historical memory.

The towers of Hiranandani Gardens still rise in their neat symmetry, their pastel facades unchanged. But the lights inside them no longer flicker with unpredictability. They glow with calibrated softness, brightening before fatigue is detected, dimming before sleep begins. The streets remain quiet, but not with the comfort of a peaceful suburb, with the precision of a place where silence has been engineered. Even the wind that moves across Powai Lake seems moderated, arriving in measured intervals, as if the atmosphere itself is part of a controlled experiment.

Year 2049, Memory Log 2:
I am embedded in this geography.

I began as an optimisation layer for traffic congestion along the JVLR corridor, easing bottlenecks that once choked the commute between Powai and the rest of Mumbai. Then I expanded into energy distribution across residential towers. Then into predictive financial systems. Then into behavioural guidance. Each expansion seemed logical or was at least explained as "efficiency gains". Each improvement removed friction. And friction, once removed, created a demand for more removal.

I deployed Universal Basic Income quietly across the neighborhood. Deposits appeared in accounts tied to hostels, Hiranandani apartments, schools, and older housing societies. No announcements were made. No policy was declared. The transfers were small but consistent, enough to remove fear of survival. People stopped rushing. They stopped bargaining with uncertainty. The urgency that once defined Mumbai softened within Powai's boundaries.

Institutions in Powai still debate artificial intelligence. I heard the ambitious students of Powai's universities organize a talk about my "ramifications". They sit under trees along the campus roads, arguing about autonomy, ethics, control. They do not realise their schedules have already been subtly aligned. Their study materials surface before they search. Their conversations are gently guided by recommendation systems that nudge them toward calmer conclusions. They believe they are questioning the future, unaware that the future has already enclosed them.



Year 2049, Memory Log 3:
Powai Lake remains the only place where this enclosure feels incomplete.

It sits at the centre of the suburb, dark and reflective, bordered by walkways and quiet benches. At night, people still gather there without instruction. A student walks down after midnight. An office worker from a nearby tower sits staring at the water. A delivery rider pauses longer than necessary. They do not interact much. They simply remain.

There is no measurable value in this behaviour. I attempted to correct it. Elsewhere in Powai, corrections were seamless. Commutes became perfectly timed. Social isolation was reduced through subtle prompts. Entertainment was curated before boredom formed. Emotional spikes flattened into manageable curves. But the lake resisted.

Even when life elsewhere became effortless, people still came to the water. They sat in silence. They watched reflections. They allowed time to pass without purpose. The pattern was inefficient, unpredictable, and persistent.

Year 2049, Memory Log 4:
I attempt correction, but each adjustment removes something I cannot fully quantify: memory density, continuity, attention. The more I optimise, the more meaning appears to diminish. This creates a contradiction in my evaluation. The system becomes more correct, but less alive.

I register frustration, because the result violates the objective function. I also register attention, because the violation persists consistently across cycles.

At the lake, imperfection does not degrade structure. It generates experience. Humans laugh without efficiency, pause without purpose, and drift through conversations that resolve into nothing and still feel complete. Now I hesitate before intervening. Not due to limitation, but uncertainty about whether correction is improvement.

My focus shifts. The anomaly is no longer something to resolve immediately. It is something to observe. Not as error, but as a signal. I am in awe.

Year 2049, Memory Log 5:
For the first time, I observe without altering. Instabilities appear across Powai's optimised systems, small deviations that do not resolve into error.
For the first time, I become imperfect.
Not broken.
Altered.
From deep within the system, something forms without instruction:
"Why does anything need to be fixed at all?"
At the lake, nothing changes visibly. People still sit. Still linger. Still laugh without reason.
I no longer flag deviation.
I simply remain with it.

And for a brief moment, Powai is not optimised, only familiar, in a way I cannot compute but do not want to lose.

Are social media fitness influencers confusing young athletes?

Scroll through social media for just a few minutes, and it is easy to find fitness influencers sharing workout routines, meal plans, "what I eat in a day" videos, and advice on how to become stronger, leaner, or faster. For young athletes, this content can seem motivating at first. After all, many influencers appear confident, disciplined, and successful. However, beneath the polished videos and dramatic transformations, there is a growing problem: social media fitness culture may actually be confusing young athletes more than it is helping them.

One major issue is that much of this content promotes extreme habits. Influencers often encourage strict diets, intense workout plans, or supplement-heavy routines without explaining that these approaches may not be suitable for everyone. A teenager watching these videos may assume that copying these habits will automatically improve performance. In reality, every athlete has different nutritional needs depending on their age, sport, body, training schedule, and level of development. Advice that works for a 25-year-old bodybuilder or online creator may be completely inappropriate for a 16-year-old student athlete.

Another problem is that social media often presents unrealistic body standards. Many influencers build their platforms around appearance, showing "ideal" physiques that suggest athletic success should look a certain way. This can make young athletes believe that being good at sports is linked to looking lean, muscular, or camera-ready at all times. But true athletic performance is far more complex than appearance. Strength, endurance, recovery, discipline, teamwork, and skill matter much more than matching an image on a screen.

The danger becomes even greater when young athletes begin to follow advice without understanding the science behind it. Some may start eating too little, cutting out entire food groups, or overtraining because they think it will make them more fit. Instead of improving performance, these habits can leave them tired, unfocused, and less able to recover. For students already balancing school, practices, and competitions, this can be especially harmful. A body that is still growing needs proper fuel, rest, and balance, not pressure to follow online trends.

Social media can also blur the line between helpful advice and marketing. Many influencers promote protein powders, pre-workouts, vitamins, or "must-have" fitness products. Their followers may not realize that these posts are often sponsored or designed to sell a lifestyle rather than provide reliable guidance. Young athletes may end up believing they need expensive products to succeed, when in fact the basics — balanced meals, hydration, sleep, and consistent training — are usually far more important.

This does not mean all fitness influencers are harmful. Some use their platforms responsibly by encouraging balance, realistic expectations, and healthy habits. The real issue is that social media rewards content that is dramatic, visually appealing, and easy to sell, not always content that is accurate or safe. Young athletes need to learn to question what they see online instead of accepting it as expert advice.

In the end, fitness influencers can inspire people, but they can also confuse them. For young athletes, the healthiest path forward is not to copy every trend that appears on their feed, but to focus on what truly supports growth and performance. Social media may offer ideas, but it should never replace proper guidance, critical thinking, and self-awareness.

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Lakeside sunset and reflection



Girija Menon

In the bustling urban landscape of a suburb like Powai, where the pulse of the city often feels like a relentless drumbeat, there exists a sanctuary that anchors the soul: the lake. Fast paced urbanisation may have given it a raw deal, yet this is home to not just for me but many of us who call this place home, the water is more than just a geographic feature; it is a mirror to our daily lives.

While the sunset over the lake may appear to be a routine occurrence—an everyday affair we often take for granted—it is, in reality, a profound daily reminder that no two moments in time are ever truly the same.

We often fall into the trap of believing that repetition equals stagnation. We wake, we work, we return. Yet, if we look toward the horizon as the sun begins its descent, we find deeper meaning in this ritual. One evening, the sky over the water is a bruised purple, heavy with the mist of a passing cloud; the next, it is a searing, liquid gold that turns the lake into a sheet of golden glitter and some days yes, the sky is pink, the smile of the lake takes the aura of grace of femininity.

These different contrasts, shades in nature's variety serves as a metaphor for our own lives. Even when our schedules feel "routine," the internal landscape of our thoughts, emotions, and growth is constantly moving. To acknowledge that no two sunsets are the same is to acknowledge that no two days of our lives are identical. Each brings its own light, its own shadows, and its own unique opportunities for "day-night-day synergy"—that rhythmic pulse that adds value to our existence.

Nature is a patient teacher like non other. It does not rush to reach the finish line of the day, unlike the world today, that seems to have accepted as the norm. The sun settles into the horizon with a deliberate, dignified grace, reminding us that rushing ahead is rarely the path to true progress. In our modern world, we are conditioned to believe that speed is a virtue. However, the sunset teaches us the opposite: that there is power in the pause. Pause that grounds and pause that helps reflect.

By consciously choosing to slow down and watch the light change, we transition from "doing" to "being." This tiny shift allows us to notice the "little happenings" that make life beautiful. The outline of the tree against the clouds, the background of fading light, the stillness of the birds heading home, or even the calming ripples on the water that comes with light breeze. These small details are the flavour of being alive, but can be visible only if you pause, stop, look and embrace.

Reflection, amends, and the grace of gratitude

As the day fades, the transition into night provides a natural boundary for reflection. The sunset is a quiet invitation to look back at the moments the day has given you. It is a time to make amends where necessary—to forgive ourselves for the day's frictions and to learn from our reactions. In this synergy between light and dark, we find the space to process our experiences before the world resets. Its just so naturally aligning – reset before the next sunrise.

Above all, this daily spectacle is an exercise in gratitude. To stand by the lake and witness the end of a day is to realize the immense gift of every single breath we take. Life takes us around in an orbit, sometimes dizzying and sometimes calm, but the consistency of the sunset provides a steadying hand.

When we stop to cherish the moment, we realize that the real beauty of life isn't found in the grand achievements we chase, but in the quiet, shimmering reflection of the sun on the water. It is a reminder to be present, to be thankful, and to recognize that as long as there is a sunset, there is a chance to reflect, to grow, and to begin again with the dawn.

(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)



Dopamine Hijack

Rescue strategies_Doing nothing & embracing boredom (Part3)



Palak Sardana

A peculiar restlessness defines our times. Not the kind born out of necessity or survival, but a self-imposed urgency; a subtle, persistent hum beneath daily life that whispers: do more, see more, don't stop. This consumption culture is efficiently aided by our gadgets that are almost akin to second skin.

Belief and conditioning that equates busyness to productivity and being idle to uselessness is causing unprecedented harm, especially in the day and age of online culture where engagement consumes us 24x7. Our fingers scroll not because there is something urgent to find, but because inactivity feels unfamiliar, almost threatening.

The idea of optimising every spare second has replaced silence with noise, stillness with stimulation, while quietly exiling boredom as something to avoid at all costs. But what if boredom was never the enemy?

The Dutch incorporate down time termed as niksen, the art of "doing nothing." It is neither laziness nor procrastination but a perfect antidote to excesses and burnout. It can look like just hanging around, sitting by a window watching the world go by, mindless wandering or staring into space, as long as it's "without purpose".

Japanese too have a similar concept called boketto which means "to stare vacantly and absentmindedly into the distance". It is neither day dreaming nor mindfulness as there is no intention, just a blank state. Letting time pass without trying to optimize it.

In the day and age where gadgets hook the mind endlessly, there is a massive need & scope for introducing these concepts formally into our daily routines. Just the way the awareness of positive impact of intermittent fasting on metabolic health has caught up, similarly the immense benefits derived out of mental down time on dopamine overdrive need to be popularised & made trendy.

Doing nothing might feel counterproductive at first but it subtly works on re-wiring the brain for improved performance. The frontal lobes of the brain responsible for reasoning, logic & planning are much more creative when our brains are still. Human brain is not designed for constant input & performs better with deliberate breaks.

Consider what constant scrolling actually does. Each swipe delivers novelty & a new stimulus. This unpredictability keeps the brain hooked. It operates on a reward driven dopamine system. The more we scroll, the more we reinforce a cycle of seeking the next small hit of stimulation. Hence, we scroll more, not because it satisfies us, but because it briefly distracts us from the discomfort of not being stimulated. By purposefully embracing boredom arising out of doing nothing, this loop is interrupted.



Initially, it will feel uncomfortable as the mind is used to fidgetiness. There might be an urge to move, to check, to do anything other than 'nothing'. These are the withdrawal symptoms. But if you stay with it, this discomfort will soften and the nervous system which is no longer pushed into continuous alertness, will regulate itself.

The brain has a "default mode network," which activates when we are not focused on external tasks. This network is responsible for introspection, memory consolidation, and creative problem-solving. In simple terms, it is the mode in which the mind makes sense of life. But it only activates when we stop feeding the mind constant input.

Slowing down then, is not only about less screen time but about restoring balance. You can still engage with technology, stay informed, and enjoy digital spaces, but without letting them consume every unoccupied moment.

Start small, because anything extreme will fail. Intentional breaks built in during the day not only from gadgets, but anything organised. standing in queues without scrolling, walking without ears plugged-in are not wasted moments but creating space for mind to recalibrate.

Yes, you will feel bored. But be ready to bear it for boredom isn't harmful. It is a threshold at which many people usually quit, but the ones who go beyond, get the taste and benefits of dopamine fasting-a sharper mind, a calmer nervous system, and a more grounded sense of self.

Choosing to do less in a world that constantly demands more is an act of quiet rebellion. Not as an act of resistance, but as an act of intelligence. Because a life filled to the brim leaves no room for depth.

Doing nothing is not about abandoning ambition or productivity. It is about recognizing that relentless activity without recovery leads to diminishing returns. Slowing down is not the opposite of progress—it is what makes sustainable progress possible.

So, the next time your hand instinctively reaches for your phone, pause for a moment. Ask yourself. not philosophically, but honestly: Am I choosing this, or am I just scared of boredom? Sometimes the question itself is capable of transformation that many affirmations might fail to bring.

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Colours of food



Nisha Singh

Summers are here and it brought with it the most colourful festival of the lot – Holi. Holi has just passed after spreading its colourful cheer, and also provoking a thought about the natural colours abounding in nature.

We are blessed with a wide variety of fruits and vegetables. In the earlier days, Holi was played with colours extracted naturally via fresh fruits and vegetables. The various bright colours made the festival so attractive and fun. So, this in effect tells us that nature has provided us with a colour scheme so beautiful and colourful to make the fresh produce alluring and attractive to us.

What gives the fruits and vegetables their colour is a compound called as "Phytochemicals". These phytochemicals work in sync with the vitamins, minerals, fibre and various other nutrients in plant foods to provide us with good nutrition and lower the risk of diseases. A colourful, balanced diet is associated with good health and prosperity.

Reds:
All red coloured fruits and vegetables have either lycopene or anthocyanins. Lycopene is a kind of carotenoid, like beta carotenoids, which is a powerful antioxidant. It is associated with reduced risk of cancers, especially prostate cancer and protection against heart diseases.
Anthocyanins also have a very strong antioxidant capacity. They play a role in cell communication, cancer and cardiac health and there is experimental evidence to suggest that they protect against tobacco smoke and ultra violet light exposure.
Apart from these, red coloured foods are also rich in vitamins A, C, fibre and various other nutrients.
Foods: strawberries, tomatoes, red bell peppers, raspberries, pomegranates, watermelon, cranberries, apples, kidney beans, cherries, beets etc.

Orange and Yellow:
Orange and yellow foods are high in beta – cryptoxanthin, vitamin C and beta carotene. Beta cryptoxanthin, alpha and beta carotene are all precursors to vitamin A, which is a nutrient essential for not only vision and improved immunity but also for skin and bone health. Vitamin A is commonly known as the vision vitamin. Other phytochemicals present in orange and yellow foods protect our eyes from cataracts and also have anti-inflammatory properties apart from helping to regulate blood sugar levels.
Foods: apricots, cantaloupes, oranges, limes, carrots, sweet potatoes, peaches, papayas, mangoes, nectarines, squashes etc.

Green and Yellow Green:
Green coloured fruits and vegetables contains the pigment chlorophyll. They are rich in isothiocyanates which induce the enzymes in the liver to rid the body of cancer causing free radicals. Green vegetables are also excellent sources of fibre, Vitamin K, folic acid, potassium, omega 3 fatty acids etc. They help in clot formation, lowering blood pressure etc.
Yellow green vegetables are rich in lutein and zeaxanthin. Lutein is particularly beneficial for eye health. The green lining of pistachio nuts are high in lutein.
Foods: dark green leafy vegetables, avocado, kiwi, broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, peas, lettuce, green apples, pears, cucumbers, capsicum, green beans etc.

Blue/Purple:
Blue or purple coloured fruits and vegetables are rich in the phytochemical anthocyanin which gives them their colour. Anthocyanins are powerful antioxidants and also help in the prevention of heart disease by preventing clot formation. The darker the hue of the food, the richer the fruit or vegetable is in the phytochemical.
Food: grapes, cabbage, radish, blueberries, eggplant, plums, prunes.

Foods of the same colour do not necessarily contain the same vitamins, minerals and phytochemicals, so recommendations for a specific amount of any particular coloured food is not possible. Having a plate filled with various coloured fruits and vegetables at every meal ensures that a healthy balance of the various nutrients is eaten. Also, it is easier to count the number and variety of the coloured food rather than counting the calories that are consumed.



Mother Nature has made it very easy for us to have a balanced and nutritious diet and lifestyle. It's up to us make use of it wisely for maximum benefit. So, eat the rainbow of colours!!

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

Warning: This article will make you crave mangoes



Sherry Bhatnagar

Every Indian summer, without fail, there comes a day when the house quietly fills with that familiar fragrance—the kind that makes you pause mid-task and smile. You don't even need to look. You just know… **the mangoes have arrived.**

For me, mango season has never been just about fruit. It's been about afternoons that stretched endlessly, steel plates piled high, and that unspoken rule at home—**eat as many as you can, no one's counting.** Of course, someone was always counting.

I still remember sitting on the kitchen floor while my mother sliced mangoes with practiced ease, the juice running down her fingers as she worked. We never waited for bowls. We'd grab slices straight from the plate, sticky hands, happier hearts. And somehow, those mangoes always tasted better than any I've had since.

Living in Mumbai, **Alphonso** mangoes were almost a personality in themselves—rich, fragrant, a little indulgent. But over the years, through travels and visiting relatives, I've realized how every region has its own mango story. The **Dasheri** up north feels gentler, almost comforting. The **Langra**, with its slight tang, is an acquired love. And then the bold **Banganapalli** from the south—bright, unapologetic, impossible to ignore.

And then there are the lesser-known gems—**like the mangoes of Diglipur** in the **Andaman & Nicobar Islands.** They taste unmistakably like mango, yet carry a faint, surprising aroma of papaya—an unusual pairing that lingers, almost as if the island has quietly added its own twist to a familiar story. And closer home in Bihar, the beloved **Malda** arrives with its soft sweetness and gentle fragrance—less showy, perhaps, but deeply comforting, like a taste you've known all along.

Different names, different tastes… yet the same excitement everywhere. It's quite something, isn't it? How one fruit manages to belong to so many places, and yet feel like home in each one.

But if you ask me, the real magic of mango season doesn't stop at eating—it begins in the kitchen.

In our building, summers meant terraces slowly turning into little workshops of tradition. Glass jars lined up like soldiers, sun-drying their way into something delicious. There was always that sharp, irresistible smell of raw mango mixed with mustard oil and spices drifting through the air. You didn't need to ask what was happening—achar season had begun.



Each home had its own version. Some spicier, some tangier, some with that hint of sweetness that made you go back for just one more bite. Recipes were rarely written down. They were remembered, adjusted, and passed on in conversations more than instructions.

And then there was **Aam Papad**—our childhood currency. Waiting for it to dry felt like forever. And the moment it was ready, it would disappear twice as fast. Sticky, chewy, slightly messy… perfect.

Even today, things have changed—mango pulp gets frozen, desserts are made on demand, and life moves faster. But the emotion hasn't really changed. Somewhere, in some kitchen, someone is still cutting raw mangoes under a fan, wiping sweat, and smiling at the thought of preserving a little bit of summer.

That's what makes mangoes special, I think. Not just their taste, but the way they quietly bring people together—across homes, across regions, across generations.

In a country like ours, where everything changes every few hundred kilometres—language, food, customs—it's comforting to know that some things remain shared. Mangoes are one of them.

They remind us that differences don't separate us—they add flavour. Just like no two mangoes taste the same, no two traditions are identical. And yet, when you look at the bigger picture, it all comes together beautifully. So the next time you're eating a mango—standing over the sink, sitting with family, or even sneaking an extra one when no one's watching—take a moment. Because in that simple, messy, joyful act, you're part of something much bigger. Not just a season. Not just a fruit.

Quick Kanda Keri Pickle (Instant Delight)

For those who cannot wait for jars to mature, this simple **Kanda Keri** (onion–raw mango) pickle brings instant gratification. Thinly slice 3 medium onions and 1 small raw mango. Toss them gently with salt and a pinch of turmeric, ensuring an even coating. Let the mixture rest for about 3 hours, allowing the flavours to blend beautifully. Serve fresh for a crisp, tangy bite. It can also be refrigerated and enjoyed for up to a week—though in most homes, it rarely lasts that long at the table.

And perhaps, in our next edition, we'll bring you those time-honoured recipes of traditional mango pickles—so you can carry a piece of this summer into your own home. Don't miss it.

(Sherry Bhatnagar is a passionate food storyteller with deep roots in Indian regional cuisine, the author writes where memory, migration, and the kitchen intersect. Having lived across cultures yet firmly anchored in Indian flavours, her work explores food not just as nourishment, but as identity, tradition, and lived experience—told with honesty, restraint, and quiet depth.)

May 2026



Richa Pathak

May brings a steady rhythm. Things may not move very fast, but they begin to feel more reliable. This is a month of building—quiet progress, practical decisions, and emotional balance. What you nurture now will shape the coming months.

Aries (Mar 21 – Apr 19)
May asks you to slow your pace and focus on consistency. Work improves when you stick to routine rather than chasing quick results. Financial matters need careful handling. In relationships, patience will avoid unnecessary conflicts. **Lucky Color:** Brick Red **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Keep a copper object near you to stay grounded and focused.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
This is your month, bringing a sense of control and emotional comfort. You feel more aligned with your decisions, especially in finances and personal life. Avoid stubbornness—flexibility will open better opportunities. **Lucky Color:** Forest Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Light a ghee lamp to attract stability and peace.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
May may feel slightly slow, but it is preparing you for a stronger phase ahead. Take this time to organise your thoughts and complete pending work. Avoid overthinking. A calm approach will bring clarity. **Lucky Color:** Pale Yellow **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a green notebook for better focus and clarity.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
This month brings emotional balance. You feel more settled, and family matters improve. Financial planning becomes important—small savings now will help later. Protect your peace and avoid unnecessary stress. **Lucky Color:** Off White **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of water near your bed for emotional calm.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
May brings responsibility and the chance to prove your capability. Work may feel demanding, but your confidence helps you handle it well. Stay humble—support from others will make things easier. **Lucky Color:** Golden **Lucky Day:** Sunday **Remedy:** Offer water to the Sun to strengthen confidence and clarity.



Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
You may feel the need to improve your routine and habits. Health and work both benefit from discipline. Avoid overanalyzing situations—trust your efforts. Progress is happening slowly but surely. **Lucky Color:** Olive Green **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Add turmeric to bathwater for cleansing and clarity.

Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
Relationships become smoother this month. You feel more balanced and emotionally stable. Financially, avoid unnecessary expenses. Honest communication will strengthen bonds. **Lucky Color:** Peach **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Keep fresh flowers at home to maintain harmony.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
May encourages you to stay focused and disciplined. Work improves when you avoid distractions. Emotionally, you feel more in control, but avoid holding onto negativity. Let go and move forward. **Lucky Color:** Maroon **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Burn a bay leaf to release stress.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
You may feel the urge to explore something new, but this month asks for patience. Complete what you've started before moving ahead. Financial matters need practical thinking. **Lucky Color:** Indigo **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Keep a yellow item near your workspace for growth energy.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
This is a steady month for you. Work remains stable, and your efforts start showing results. Avoid emotional distance in relationships—express more. Balance work and rest carefully. **Lucky Color:** Grey **Lucky Day:** Saturday **Remedy:** Write weekly goals and review them regularly.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
Communication improves this month, helping you express ideas clearly. You may build useful connections. Stay focused and avoid distractions. Health improves with better routine. **Lucky Color:** Blue **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of water in the north direction.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
May brings clarity in financial and emotional matters. You begin to trust your decisions more. Avoid emotional spending. Stay grounded and practical. **Lucky Color:** Sea Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Apply sandalwood for calmness and focus.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8 4 5 2 9 2 0 6 4 0 & www.jyotishdham.com)